

thought. There is a grainy grimness about the future. About bills and fees and stuff that only you carried on your shoulder.

When I did this exercise, my overwhelming thought was to reach out from beyond the dead and help the family out. To point where the papers are kept; to whisper passwords they were searching for; to go and punch Yama in the face and say, 'It wasn't my time yet, I still had to fix my family's future. And eat that mango kulfi falooda that I'd been salivating for for so long. And just finish that last episode of *Better Call Saul!*' Oh well. Nice to open the eyes!

When you die an untimely death you leave lots of things midway – it could be a meal, sleep, a conversation, a fight, a joke, a holiday plan. You also leave your family midway in their journey through life – both physically and financially.

While we can work on leaving only good memories with our family by becoming the person we think we are, the financial piece is much easier to do. You need to figure out how much the family will need to live, without you bringing in the monthly income, and how much for the future of the kids' education and marriage. You may have dependent parents and a spouse who does not earn, and may need to provide for them till they are alive as well. Think of this as just income replacement – how big a lump sum (that will earn a return) do you need today so that your income will not be missed by the family if you are not around.

The other big expense that will hit the family if you suddenly disappear is the debt you have. Home loans, car loans, education, personal loans, credit card debt – all of this will need to be paid back if you are to continue using what was bought with a loan. While there are few cases of a family getting thrown out of the house in India by a bank, do you really want that pressure on your family when the problem can be easily resolved? You need a life insurance cover to look after all of these expenses and costs if your lifeline is cut before time.

You'd have realized by now that we're looking at a very large sum as the life insurance cover. Add up the cover (look in the policies you have and add up the figure under 'sum assured') you have in all your existing policies and see how much your life insurance cover is – not the value of the policy when it matures, but what the beneficiary gets if you die.